

**O'ZBEKISTON RESPUBLIKASI
OLIY TA'LIM, FAN VA
INNOVATSIYALAR VAZIRLIGI
JIZZAX DAVLAT PEDAGOGIKA
UNIVERSITETI XORIJIY TILLAR
FAKULTETI INGLLIZ TILI AMALIY
KURSI KAFEDRASI**



**Globallashuv sharoitida
kommunikativ tillarni
o'qitish tashabbuslari
Xalqaro onlayn ilmiy-amaliy
konferensiya
TO'PLAMI**

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USING HUMOUR TECHNIQUES IN FOREIGN LANGUAGE CLASSES

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Abstract: *This paper examines the integration of humorous genres into the foreign language teaching process as a potential humorous technique for developing pragmatic competence, expanding vocabulary, improving grammatical skills and enhancing learners' speaking.*

Keywords: *humour, humour techniques, pragmatic competence*

Аннотация: *В данной статье рассматривается интеграция юмористических жанров в процесс обучения иностранному языку как потенциальная юмористическая техника для развития прагматической компетенции, расширения лексического запаса, совершенствования грамматических навыков и улучшения разговорной речи учащихся.*

Ключевые слова: *юмор, приемы юмора, прагматическая компетенция*

Annotatsiya: *Ushbu maqolada xorijiy til o'rgatish jarayonida yumor janrlarini integratsiya qilish, talabalarining pragmatik kompetentligini oshirish, lug'at boyligini kengaytirish, grammatik ko'nikmalarini mukammallashtirish va so'zlab berish malakalarini yaxshilash uchun potensial yumoristik usul sifatida ko'rib chiqiladi.*

Kalit so'zlar: *yumor, yumor usullari, pragmatic kompetensiya*

In Higher Education, one of the challenges teachers face is the students' attention deficit. Students tend to get distracted easily if the lessons become tedious and structural. They start checking up on their mobile phones (if using mobile phones is allowed in the institution), social media or talking to student partners. Teacher mission, in this case, is to be able to keep the attention of the students on the class and its content so that together with the students, they reach the learning outcomes. One can use technological input, interactive methods and other possible tools for this purpose. In addition to the techniques mentioned, this article suggests humour-integrated learning in foreign

language classes to keep student's attention and increase motivation. It suggests to use genres of humour as possible humour techniques as a motivating tool which can sustain students' attention and help to develop different language skills and competencies. Particularly, this article explains humour genres including parody, satire, caricature, cartoons, comics and sketch and discusses how they can be integrated into the class by providing tips for activities.

As a small reference, to understand what genres humour can be categorized one can turn to Hativa [5; p. 226] who differentiates verbal, non-verbal and combined (i.e. types of humour which integrate both verbal and non-verbal forms) types of humour. To verbal types of humour, namely humour based on words or text Hativa includes jokes, anecdotes, language play, irony, humorous riddles, jargons, taboo language, limerick, comic verse, humorous comment, understatement. Non-verbal types of humour are cartoons, caricatures, photons and visual puns and other types of humour which may initiate humorous effect without using a text. Impersonation, parody, satire, monologue and skit are considered as combined both verbal and non-verbal type of humour.

Parody

In Uzbek Language Thesaurus dictionary [9; p. 226] the following definition is given to parody: “Adabiyot va ba'zan musiqada, tasviriy san'atda: biror asarga taqlidan yaratilgan, uning zaif tomonlariga xajviy, kinoyaviy yondashilgan asar; satirik o'xshatma.” (direct translation from Uzbek - In literature and sometimes in music, in visual arts: a work created by imitating some other piece, approaching its weak sides with comic exaggeration; a satirical simile). A parody is defined as “a piece of writing, music, acting, etc. that deliberately copies the style of somebody/something, in order to be humorous” [16] in the Oxford Learner's Dictionary. A parody can be made for music, a literary work, a film or an artwork. The purpose of parody is to imitate, make fun of or comment on the creative, original work. According to Kulinich, parody is not always making fun of the original piece, on the contrary, it is a type of showing respect to the author and his/her work [8]. When one reads a parodic text or listens to a parodic song, he/she usually recognizes what work it is imitating, making fun of or commenting, on

because they are usually popular pieces (this is also the point of the parody that the spectators/readers and listeners can detect the parodized piece). Parodized songs usually consist of the same melody but changed lyrics to bring the amusement element to work (e.g., Weird Al Yankovic's parody song "Eat it" for Michael Jackson 'Beat it') [19; p. 10]. Parody movies deform the scenes from the original movies for the fun effect, and books may also relate to other works for the purpose of parody by copying some elements and creatively changing them. Studies show that using parodies in teaching helps students better understand the original work because a well-done parody requires a full understanding of the gist and the style of the original work. One of the impactful activities in a foreign language teaching classroom could be using parodic songs to enhance students' skills of understanding parody within a communicative context.

Procedure:

1. Find parodies to popular songs which are suitable for classroom context (one of the examples can be Weird Al Yankovic's parody song "Eat it" for Michael Jackson 'Beat it')
2. Give students the lyrics of original song and play it. Keep in mind that some of the words from the lyrics can be pre-taught so that students comprehend them.
3. Ask students to discuss the song and discuss the meaning of it in pairs. Then discuss the song with the whole class. Ask students to share their opinions.
4. After the discussion is completed, provide students with the lyrics of parody song of the song they previously listened to. Scaffolding can be done by pre-teaching some of the difficult vocabulary.
5. Play the song (Weird Al Yankovic's parody song "Eat it").
6. Repeat the instructions provided in step 3.
7. After the discussion over, you may ask students to work in pairs to create parody songs to popular songs which they like. [20; p. 298–299]

This activity lets students practise their listening, reading and writing skills. Moreover, students develop their creative writing skills. From a pragmatic competence perspective, this activity can serve as a tool to strengthen students' skills in detecting

irony, sarcasm, or cynicism and inferencing the allusions used to cultural phenomena. Besides, students will learn the appropriateness of the used language in certain contexts. Depending on the difficulty of the song, this activity can be done with higher-level students. If used with lower-level students, teachers can scaffold some of the elements with which students may have difficulty working.

Satire is a more deliberate form of humour and in Uzbek Language Thesaurus dictionary it is defined as “Adabiyot va san’atda: kishidagi nuqsonlar va hayotdagi kamchiliklar, salbiy hodisalarni ayovsiz tanqid qilish, fosh etish hamda shunday mazmunda yozilgan badiiy asar” [10; p. 459] (direct translation from Uzbek - In literature and art: a literary work that criticizes, brings to light human flaws and deficiencies in life, negative events without mercy, a literary work written in this style) and in Oxford Learner’s Dictionary as “a way of criticizing a person, an idea or an institution in which you use humour to show their faults or weaknesses; a piece of writing that uses this type of criticism” [17]. Originally, the word satire comes from the Latin word ‘satura’. In order to understand satire, a person should have a good understanding of modern trends in social, cultural and political affairs. Therefore, using satire in teaching is an effective tool to develop students’ critical thinking skills because students, when reading a satiric text, should build inferences on a situation described in the text, try to make associations and interpret exaggerations and allusions, which are usually the tools of making a satire. It is very important at the illocutionary level to understand the satire, as it may be complex to comprehend it in the target language due to language barriers or not being able to infer the information implied through the satire. Satire can be used as a humour technique to develop students’ pragmatic competence in comprehending the implied meaning at the same time, depending on lesson objectives, satirical texts, audio or videos can be used as materials [19]. In order to teach students authentic humorous instances from the target culture, one can use light bulb jokes which are widely used in English speaking countries context. According to the Internet resource, the following definition is given to light bulb jokes:

“A light bulb jokes are jokes that ask how many people of a certain group are needed to change, replace, or screw in a light bulb. Generally, the punch line answer

highlights a stereotype of the target group. There are numerous versions of the light bulb joke satirizing a wide range of cultures, beliefs and occupations.” [7]

For example:

Question: How many philosophers does it take to change a lightbulb?

Answer: Hmmm... well there's an interesting question isn't it?

Answer: Three. One to change it and two to stand around arguing over whether or not the lightbulb exists.

Answer: Define “lightbulb” [7]

By using light bulb jokes, teachers can teach new vocabulary, jargon or idioms. Besides, based on them, role-play activities can be initiated in which students will practise their speaking skills and enhance their pragmatic competence related to inferencing and implied meaning. Besides, in role-play, students will learn turn taking, necessary degree of politeness and discourse competence (engaging in humorous conversation by being able to comprehend and by need create own light bulb jokes and satirical instances). These types of activities can be suggested to start at the intermediate level as role-plays can be challenging for students as students need to understand the meaning behind the jokes first.

Caricature, Cartoon, Comics

As it is given in the Oxford Learner’s Dictionary, the word caricature means “a funny drawing or picture of somebody that exaggerates some of their features” [15]. A similar definition is given in Uzbek Language Thesaurus dictionary: “Kulgi yoki mazax qilish maqsadida kishi yoki biror narsa-hodisning salbiy tomonlarini xarakteri xususiyatlarini ataylab bo‘rttirib ishlangan hajviy rasm” [11; p. 322] (direct translation from Uzbek - A humorous picture that deliberately exaggerates the negative aspects of a person or a thing, an event for laughter or mockery.) It may be a picture; however, sometimes, it may also be used to denote a funny saying about someone or something that exaggerates his/her/its description of traits or characteristics to gain a humorous effect.

Figure 1.

Caricature sample picture describing a teacher playing the guitar [18]



To understand caricature, one should draw the difference between *caricature* and *cartoon*. A cartoon is defined as a funny drawing in a newspaper or magazine regarding politics and trend events to elevate a discussion. Frequently, cartoons are used as an interpretation of the event; therefore, mostly, cartoons are associated with the term ‘political cartoon’. In the article text, multiple words may be used, however, a small cartoon with some text bubbles can swiftly convey the meaning that the article text bears:

Figure 2.

A cartoon by Jim Morin describing Brexit [12]



Another humour technique which is based on images and text is a comic strip. Oxford Learner’s Dictionary [15] defines a *comic strip* (see Figure 3) as multiple images in boxes with text telling a short story which are published in newspapers. Novitasari [13] defines comics (comic strips) as sequences of images with meaningful text which send a special message to the reader. There are two types of comics; comic books and comic strips. Comic book is a collection of comics gathered in one book, whereas comic strips are usually found in newspapers or magazines.

Figure 3.

A comic strip example from comic strips series Calvin and Hobbes [13]



Using comic strips, teachers can do a lot of activities with their students depending on the language they would like to practice (e.g., grammar or vocabulary). Comic strips also help students understand the subtleties of humour in the target language culture. For example, with the comic strip, which is given in Figure 3, one can practice verb forms and ask students to analyse why particular verb tenses are used in certain situations. Another instance is given in Figure 4. By using that cartoon, teachers can teach grammar and how the meaning of the future can be presented by using the Present Tense.

Figure 4.

Cartoon used as a material to teach future forms [18].



Sketch

The term *sketch* or *skit* is connected with the small theatrical scene sequences with a humorous effect. Therefore, sometimes the term may be used as a sketch comedy or sketch show [2]. Cambridge Online Dictionary [1] gives a similar definition of sketch: “a short, humorous part of a longer show on stage, television, or radio”. According to Douglas [21], sketches have been popular since ancient times. Since in Ancient Greece and Rome, Central Asia there used to be open-air markets (in some regions, they still exist). People in the open-air markets were entertained by “jugglers, musicians most likely, amusing sketches of some sort” [21; p.1]. Currently, the genre of sketch comedy

is widely employed in theatres, on television and radio. To illustrate, there are some popular TV shows that use sketches: KVN (a popular Russian TV show in which students from different universities compete by performing different comedic sketches) or American TV show Key and Peele show.

As sketches include dialogues, they can be used as a tool to develop different language skills of students, including speaking, listening, vocabulary etc. They can also be used to enhance students' pragmatic competence. By doing activities with sketches upper-intermediate or advanced level students can develop their understanding of the usage of multiple types of speech acts, routines or the usage of implicatures in a humorous context. Other components which can be practised include turn-taking, degree of politeness, the tone of the speech in humorous discourse and others. Sketches can be used in a role play activity in which students act out the sketch which they read (listened to or watched) during the class. Teachers may use some scaffolding by pre-teaching some words or explaining some cultural phenomenon when doing such activities.

Procedure:

1. Select a video of a humorous sketch by avoiding the videos which do not match the classroom context (avoid for example, uncensored language which can be offensive or explicit). One of the sample videos can be “Funny Hugh Laurie & Stephen Fry” comedy sketch! 'Your name, sir?' [3]. In this sketch the British Policeman is writing the contact details of a person and there are some humorous instances in it.
2. Play the video of the sketch.
3. Ask some students to volunteer themselves as those who will role-play this sketch.
Share with the text of the video sketch with volunteer-students.
4. Ask the students to role-play the sketch.
5. After students are done, they may reflect on how difficult it was to role-play the sketch and to bring out humorous discourse (e.g., using special tone, degree of politeness in communication with the police officer and etc)

Some of the speech acts that can be practised based on the video can include requesting information, confirming information, clarifying the misunderstanding,

expressing surprise etc. Also, pragmatic routines such as initiation of polite turn-taking (e.g., excuse me, can I ask you something), polite addressing (e.g., May I see your ID please) and asking for information (e.g., could I just have your name please).

In conclusion, one can say that humour techniques can be used to develop students pragmatic competence by creating favourable conditions to authentic language. It can help students to practise implicatures, speech acts and routines. Teachers can choose the activities based on the learning outcomes they pursue in a concrete class. Moreover, students can increase their vocabulary and grammar skills by working with the humorous texts. It can be taken into account that students may need some scaffolding, because some of the humour instances can be very culture specific or the vocabulary of the certain material can be not in the level suitable for students. It can be noted that some of the information related to culture can be pre-taught or discussed before-hand. Furthermore, teachers can discuss with students the differences between Uzbek culture and the target language culture. Regarding the vocabulary, the new words can also be given before the exposure to the humour material. However, if teachers decide not to pre-teach the complex words, the words' meaning can be deciphered during the discussions of the texts and audio-video materials.

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